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Mahatma Gandhi Institute of
Education for Peace and
Sustainable Development

Skill 8: Compassion

Module Objectives

By the end of this skill, you will be able to:

- Define compassion
- Identify thinking traps to compassion
- Recognize that compassion is not a weakness
- Explain the three necessary components of compassion
- Demonstrate techniques to practice compassion to different groups

What is Compassion? And Common Thinking traps to Compassion

In SEEK, we define compassion as the wish to ease the suffering of another rooted in care for their well-being and a degree of self-confidence.

However, something that often blocks our ability to practice compassion is falling into thinking traps.

Thinking traps, or cognitive distortions, are ways our mind can trick us into believing things that aren't true.

Thinking traps to Compassion

Compassion as Weakness	Many people mistakenly believe that being compassionate means being weak or allowing others to take advantage of you. However, true compassion often requires strength and standing firm against people or institutions when giving in would cause harm. For instance, standing up to someone who is being unfair can be an act of compassion,
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	both for yourself and others. Being a "pushover" or "doormat" is not genuine compassion; it may stem from harmful thinking traps like empathic distress, where we become overwhelmed by others' emotions.
Not Seeing Common Humanity	Sometimes we fail to see others' suffering because we don't recognize our shared humanity. Even if someone seems to have no problems, they likely experience difficulties that aren't seen to us, like emotional pain, financial worries, or health issues. By understanding that all humans suffer in some way, we can avoid the trap of overlooking others' suffering. For example, a classmate who always seems cheerful might be dealing with stress at home that we don't know about.
In-Group Bias	We naturally feel more compassion for people we know and like, but much less for strangers or those we dislike. This In-Group Bias prevents us from extending our compassion to everyone. For instance, we might go out of our way to help a friend in need, but ignore the struggles of someone we don't know or don't share a good relationship with. Overcoming this bias helps us develop a broader and more inclusive sense of compassion.
Powerlessness	When we feel powerless, we believe that our actions or thoughts can't make a difference, which can block our compassion. This trap makes us feel helpless and leads to apathy. For example, if you see news about a large-scale disaster such as earthquake or flood, you might feel like there's nothing you can do to help, and this feeling of powerlessness can prevent you from taking any action at all. Building confidence in our ability to make even small changes can help us overcome this trap and act with compassion.

	By recognizing and addressing these thinking traps, we can develop a stronger and more effective sense of compassion that isn't limited by bias, powerlessness, or misconceptions about what it means to be compassionate.
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Is compassion a Weakness?

Many people believe that showing compassion means we have to sacrifice our own needs or let others take advantage of us. However, compassion is not a sign of weakness. In fact, it's a powerful force that motivates us to ease the suffering of others while also strengthening us. Compassion can give us confidence, hope, and energy because it connects us to a deep sense of purpose and meaning.

Compassion as Strength: Compassion is about genuinely caring for the well-being of others, but it doesn't mean ignoring your own needs or allowing others to take advantage of you. For example, imagine a friend who constantly asks for favors without considering your needs. Compassion doesn't mean saying "yes" every time and neglecting your own well-being. Instead, true compassion might involve setting boundaries, so you can help them in a way that's sustainable for you both.

Compassion outside our in-group: Compassion isn't just for people we know and like—it should extend to everyone, including those outside our immediate circle. For example, if you see a stranger struggling with a heavy load, offering to help, even though you don't know them, is an act of extended compassion. This type of compassion recognizes that all humans have value, and we should care about their well-being, regardless of their relationship to us.

Compassion as a Motivation: It's important to remember that compassion is a motivation—it drives us to want to help others—but it doesn't tell us what the best action is in every situation. We need to combine compassion with critical inquiry and understanding. For example, if someone is struggling with a difficult decision, your compassion might motivate you to help, but critical inquiry will guide you to offer advice that's more logical, and supportive, rather than just telling them what to do.

Three Components of Compassion

Infographic

1) Noticing Suffering

It's often easy to see obvious forms of outward suffering, such as someone crying or bleeding from a wound. But people also suffer or have needs in ways that are less noticeable.

Example: A coworker might appear to be handling their workload well, but if you notice that they are increasingly withdrawn or seem distracted, they might be dealing with stress. Recognizing these less visible signs of suffering is the first step toward offering support.

2) Empathic Concern

Noticing suffering and the needs of others is not enough; we must feel that the sufferers deserve our compassion and care.

Example: If you see a stranger struggling to carry heavy bags, empathic concern is what makes you want to offer help, even though you don't know them personally. It's the feeling that everyone deserves kindness and help, regardless of who they are.

3) A Sense of Agency

Without confidence in our ability to act if needed, our compassion can become ineffective, leaving us feeling powerless and eventually apathetic due to empathic distress.

Example: If a friend is going through a tough time, your sense of agency might prompt you to offer a listening ear or practical help, like helping them with chores. Believing that your actions can help, even in small ways, helps you practice compassion.

Reflection

Reflect on a time when you needed to be compassionate towards others, but also had to consider your own needs. How did you balance the two?

Three levels of Compassion

Wishing Compassion

Say you learn about floods in another city. An example of **Wishing Compassion** would be, "I wish they were free from suffering." In this scenario you notice others are suffering and naturally wish for them to be free from harm and to be happy. At this level, you take no personal responsibility for alleviating the suffering of those you are impacted by the situation.

Example: Imagine you hear about floods in a city you don't live in. You might think, "I hope the people there are safe and that the situation gets better soon." While you genuinely wish for their well-being, you don't take any action beyond this thought.

Aspiring Compassion

The next level, **Aspiring Compassion**, includes more urgency, intensity, and some personal responsibility for reducing the suffering of others. You may think of small ways you could make the lives of those impacted by the earthquake easier. Like: "It'd be great for their suffering to end. Maybe I can send in a small donation or help with rescue work."

Example: After hearing about the floods, you feel moved to do more and think, "I really hope they get the help they need. Maybe I can donate to a relief fund or spread awareness on social media to encourage others to help."

Engaged Compassion

The third level is **Engaged Compassion**. At this level you feel great urgency to end the suffering of others and take on personal responsibility for doing all that you can to do so.

Perhaps you say, "They must feel better. I'm going to do whatever I can to help those suffering from the aftermath of the earthquake!"

Example: With Engaged Compassion, you might decide, "I need to do something to help those affected by the wildfire. I'm going to personally collect and send relief material, volunteer a local organization that is helping the victims, or even travel to the area to help with recovery efforts."

Remember, it may not be possible to experience Engaged Compassion for all the suffering you see in the world. You need to ground your compassion for others in self-compassion and realistic expectations. It's possible to experience engaged compassion for one cause and wishing compassion for another and that's OK!